

KF12 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Try me and know my anxious thoughts. See if there is any way in way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

If you can, make it a habit to have some purified water with you during the meeting. Sipping water helps your body process what you are experiencing.

Mindfulness training strengthens our ability to focus with endurance. We are then able to learn the skills we need to deconstruct our judgmental reactions. If you find that you struggle with the mindfulness training, allow yourself to struggle without judging the struggle. Observe any frustration or despair that you might feel, and remember that enduring those feelings is part of your training. Give yourself the gift of compassion while you practice endurance.

Let’s continue the **SALT Process**.

1. S is for Skin

Assume a mindfulness posture, and breathe. *(Pause)* Notice where your skin is and what is beyond your skin. Perhaps your skin is sensing the air around you or the fabric of your clothing. *(Pause for 10 seconds)* Now, guide your attention to observe only what is within your skin—your sensations, your thoughts, and your feelings. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

2. A is for Assess

Allow an event or an outcome to come to mind, one that you have judged as evil or as a threat. Observe how your body feels when you think about that event or situation. *(Pause)* Assess on a scale of one to ten how uncomfortable those sensations are. *(Pause)* If you feel distress or are distracted during your mindfulness practice, you might try using the Dragon Breath. The Dragon Breath is a forced exhaling breath that comes from your diaphragm, loud and strong—the sort of breath that would fog a mirror. I will demonstrate it for you. *(Demonstrate the Dragon Breath)* Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

3. L is for Look

Now we can look for the fear behind the assessment. Usually, the nature and extent of our fear is irrational. We might ask ourselves: *Of whom or of what am I afraid? What threatens my Idol Self or*

my pride system? Am I experiencing self-hate or the dread of self-hate? Ask God to help you identify your fear. Remember that your conscious fears are mostly of self, of others, or of loss and will have characteristics particular to your Idol type. (Pause) Observe your fear without judgment. It is bringing you information about the grip that the Idol has on your life. (Pause) You might try welcoming the fear and thanking it for what it is telling you about the quality of your trust, or faith. Breathe. (Pause for 30 seconds)

4. T is for Tell

Tell God about your fear and, if you can, tell Him why you feel afraid. *(Pause 10 seconds)* Now, ask God to tell you the truth about what you fear and to fill this misoriented place of fear with the positive motivations of trust, hope, and love. You might wish to use a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now bring yourself back into correspondence with your environment, that which is outside your skin. While you breathe, allow what is within you to calmly observe and respond to what is without. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Our hymn for this confession is *All the Way My Savior Leads Me*, by Fanny J. Crosby. This hymn is especially meaningful because Fanny became blind shortly after her birth. She wrote over 8,000 hymns.

All the way my Savior leads me. What have I to ask beside?
Can I doubt His tender mercy, who through life has been my Guide?
Heav'nly peace, divinest comfort, here by faith in Him to dwell!
For I know, whate'er befall me, Jesus doeth all things well;
For I know, whate'er befall me, Jesus doeth all things well.¹

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

This month we are focusing on KF Confession 3:

We constructed legal systems based on our own assessment of good and evil.

Let's look at the **Two Paths Worksheet** again.

When we are afraid of something or feel threatened, we are tricked into thinking that the threat is our business. Anything that scares us feels like our business because we feel that we must do something to ward off every threat. Without any consideration, we go straight into judging as bad or evil whatever has threatened us. We do this because we have already allowed our hearts to attach to a certain outcome—an outcome that we have judged as good. When we experience events or when people make choices that threaten our desired outcome, we feel fear, and our fear compels us to judge. We then try to control the situation, hoping to force an outcome that will deliver us from fear and save our pride. We are not thinking: *I want to change myself first so that I can learn to really love in this situation.* We are more likely to tell ourselves the story that this situation is our business and it is up to us to grab control.

If we are suffering, it is natural to want to change our circumstances. However, if we try to force change that supports our Idol Self and its judgments, our efforts are egocentric, compulsive, focused on the quick fix, and ultimately destructive. In this condition, anything that scares us feels like our business. Our creative minds are conscripted into supporting the tyranny of the illusions that we believe will support our survival. Our sole aim is to escape whatever our bodies perceive as danger and a threat. We might get what we want in the short-term, but we lose our lives, damage our souls, and harm others in the process.

The **Two Paths Worksheet** can help us learn how to respond to suffering in a healthy way that will lead to positive outcomes. This worksheet is unique among KF worksheets in that it exercises our imagination to explore what is possible when we live in non-judgment.

Let's look at steps 7–10 of the **Two Paths Worksheet**.

7. Event

It is your business to build new outcomes in your life. At the bottom left of the worksheet, you can record the event that scared or delighted your Idol Self. Hopefully, you have already recognized the event that triggered fear or euphoria. Let me remind you that euphoria is the ecstatic release from fear; it is the illusion of success. Just like fear, euphoria can take us down the Judgment Path, which leads to misorientation. Whether we react with fear or euphoria, the situation is not necessarily our business—but we know through our KF training that *our fear* is certainly *our business*. We want to become people of no fear so that the love of God can flow through us into this messed-up world. Holding fear in our bodies interferes with that goal. When we accept that our fear is our responsibility, we can observe it with compassion and then invest our beautiful energy in the kind of training that helps us make oriented choices, leading to glorious outcomes.

8. Love believes

Next, we can access our creative mind and record under step 8 what a *long-tempered* response to our fear might be. When you have a fear reaction to an event, you might ask yourself: *Is this situation my business?* Asking yourself that question lengthens your temper, and your answer will weed out a lot of unnecessary and wasteful effort.

9. Story

Now move up to the story. Try to list, without judgment, the simple facts that led to the event. This is objective evidence. The Idol loves its illusions and drama, but the True Self thrives on facts.

10. Rejoicing in the truth

What have you learned about yourself, others, or life from this event? If you can lay aside your pride and the misoriented illusions that force compulsive reactions, you can look for the training opportunity in the situation. This is *rejoicing in the truth*. Your feelings, too, are facts that tell you something about who you are, but you now understand that feelings are rarely reliable guides for evaluating an event. Those feelings and choices are your business. You can honor your feelings about the situation by simply allowing them to be and then making choices based on the objective evidence of the story. By committing yourself to the truth, you are positioned to take an action that will invite a more oriented outcome. You can train your True Self to recognize truth and give the Holy Spirit a chance to teach you what is real.

When I talk about business, I really mean responsibilities. We live in a real world that generates real business that must be attended to. All this business falls into three categories:

- **My business**—which is about me, my contribution, and my role in the community.
- **Other people's business**—which is about them, their contribution, and their role.
- **God's business**—which is everything else.

The business of people is personal care, and this includes food, shelter, material/spiritual/personal development, health (which is essential and the first priority), livelihood, and responsibilities in the community. God's business is beyond our abilities and perception. His business is always in our best interests and is accomplished with our co-operation.

When you are experiencing an event, observe what your mind is doing and consider this question: *Is this my business, other people's business, or God's business?* Tell God about it and then use the **Two Paths Worksheet** and your mindfulness training to bring yourself back to your business.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord, help me stick to my business. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

Let's remind ourselves of KF Confession 3:

We constructed legal systems based on our own assessment of good and evil.

If you start thinking about your business, you are more likely to make choices that create stable and oriented outcomes. Of course, your Idol Self does not want you to think about your business. To keep you enslaved to your search for idealized glory, the pride system of your Idol will oppose your healthy choices and manipulate you with fear. Once you have experienced real peace and joy, however, you will not be so easily manipulated. You will start fighting for your liberty.

Think about how much a hunter relies on fear or euphoria to capture his prey. He frightens it out into the open where he can shoot it, or he uses bait to lure it into a snare. His prey will be either terrified by the fear of death or feel euphoric about finding a convenient tasty morsel. Both the fear of death and the euphoric release from the fear of death are used by the hunter to dominate his prey. In the same way, your Idol Self, or another person's Idol Self, will be very tempted to use threat or a tasty morsel to manipulate you. In KF we are learning not to be manipulated by fear.

In his letter, James teaches us that life's experiences, or experiments, reveal the quality of our trust and trustworthiness. Rather than trying to escape life's experiments through mindless reactions and judgments, we are encouraged to welcome these experiences with joy because they reveal the truth about who we are and the truth about the world around us. Our Idol Self is the self of illusions. It does not want to see the truth about itself or about life. Our True Self is the self of truth. It can only thrive in truth,

and it rejoices in the truth of what is revealed. When we live out of our True Self, we seek solutions to our problems without wavering in our commitment to the truth. We courageously allow endurance to productively work in our lives. We are single-minded. We believe, without judging, what we see in ourselves and others. From that place of believing, we can be perceptive, open-minded, and creative. Love rejoices in the truth. It does not rejoice in illusions or in what it wants or needs to believe. Love believes and trusts all things that are true. Free of judgment, love is at liberty to trust the truth of what it sees and take action based on that truth. *Believing it* means that we do not jump to conclusions or get derailed by automatic reactions that are programmed to deliver us from fear. When we simply believe, we can step back and observe. Love quiets the emotions and is quick to hear, slow to speak, and slow to wrath.² The True Self prepares itself with love so that it can respond to reality with productive action rather than react to the Idol's fear, illusions, and judgments. With long-tempered practice, you will learn to default to truth and love when faced with life's experiments.

As human creatures, we can be like wild animals that react to threat in mindless and preprogrammed ways. We are so habituated to reacting with fear that we rarely make healthy choices when we feel threatened. We will need to train hard in order to change our conditioning. Karis Fellowships is like the gym of your soul; it provides many tools that you can use to plan your love work-out. The founding members of KF realized that they needed to be reminded, at least weekly, of their goals and of the tools available for dealing with their fear productively. They also realized that they needed a vehicle for tracking their progress toward orientation. That is why we developed the weekly training meetings and mini-meetings. We are addicts who use fear as a drug to help us avoid facing up to the reality of our situation. If we want to recover from our addiction, we will need to identify ourselves as addicts and work to change our habits.

Let's return to James, chapter 1. In this passage, James combines the metaphor of hunting with the metaphor of breeding livestock, but you won't notice these images in English translations. The Bible is really quite unabashed about sex. The writers are not ashamed that we, as male and female creatures, engage in procreation. They respect the power of sex by teaching us to use it gloriously.

This is my version of **James 1:13–21**.

¹³Let no one say when tempted into misorientation, "I am being examined by God." Consider this: God is incapable of being tempted with evil (we actually saw that when Jesus was tested in the wilderness) and He does not tempt anyone with evil. ¹⁴Here is the truth: each one of us is tempted when he or she is lured away by the craving to relieve fear, just as the hunter's prey is lured with bait into a snare. ¹⁵Then when that craving has been captured and taken prisoner (or we can use the metaphor of one of our prize cows getting together with the undesirable bull next door), that craving, coupled with fear, gives birth to misorientation; and when misorientation reaches full term, it produces death as its offspring. ¹⁶My beloved siblings, do not be led astray like unwitting prey by the bait of the hunter, or by the craving of a prize heifer. ¹⁷The hunter's bait seems like a gift, and you might feel euphoria; but every gift that God gives and every benefit that promotes our true potential comes from above, coming down from the Father of Lights, with whom there is no variation or shifting shadow where a hunter could hide. You can trust the Father's gifts. ¹⁸Know this, my beloved siblings: the Father never intended death to be the harvest of these times of trial; rather, it is His intention to produce our True Selves by the creative process and the first principle of truth so that we would be a kind of first fruits among His creatures. ¹⁹Now let everyone be quick to hear, like wary prey;

slow to speak (don't make noise!); and slow to wrath, which causes us to act recklessly.

²⁰For human wrath and judgment do not do the work necessary to achieve orientation to God.

Take a deep breath.

In this passage, we can see how our attachments, fears, and cravings trick us into taking the Judgment Path. Our fears trigger the compulsion to snatch, escape, and defend our pride. When an event feels threatening, we run out into the open like startled rabbits; and when an event presents to us an opportunity for easy gratification, we cannot resist our craving to take the bait. Whenever we act out of fear or euphoria, we are seeking to save our idealized life. The hunter is your Idol Self, full of pride, judgments, stories, fears, and self-hate, taking you prisoner and planting in your precious soul the seeds of misorientation. Those seeds flourish like weeds in your weakened soul and choke out your true life. That is the outcome of the Judgment Path.

You, however, are a child of the Father of Lights, whose intention is not to hunt you down and hurt you but to give you gifts of truth that promote your potential and glory. The Father knows your longings, and rather than using those longings to deceive you, He wants to lead you into the right pasture where the Spirit can plant within your soul the good gifts that lead to a fulfilled and glorious life.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Father of Lights, train me with Your gifts to give up my addiction to the Idol's fears. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and, if you wish, prepare to take some notes. Assume a mindfulness posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider a situation that tempts you to take the bait. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from each section a few phrases that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider a situation that tempts you to take the bait*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. Acknowledge with compassion whatever you may be experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush our feelings or thoughts from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. Breathe, and hold your experience up to the light

as you *consider a situation that tempts you to take the bait*. (Pause) Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe, and bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing when you *consider taking the bait*. What sensations are there? (Pause) Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what craving or panic feels like, or perhaps euphoria or disgust. (Pause) If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to respectfully observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider this situation that tempts you to take the bait*. Do you feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. (Pause) Do you judge this situation as life or death, release or threat? What are your reasons? What story do you want to tell? (Pause) Is this situation a regular pattern in your life? Are you afraid of something—of being wrong, of missing out, of exertion? You might be afraid of your own power, or of someone else's power? (Pause) Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Heal

God created us to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have been feeling like you feel when they have *considered taking the bait*. You are a human creature and are not alone in your feelings. (Pause) Feelings are just chemical reactions in your body bringing you information. With training, you can choose what you will do with those feelings. (Pause) You can observe yourself with compassion and learn something from what you have just experienced. When a fear or judgment signals you through the body, you can focus on your body and your breath rather than getting caught up in a story and reacting. Breathe, and help your body process your experience with a long exhaling breath. (Pause for 30 seconds)

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank you for this time together to heal and train. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our glory and to the truth. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ *All the Way My Savior Leads Me* by Fanny J. Crosby (1820–1915), www.youtube.com/watch?v=ekUELQcnQIM.

² James 1:19.